

General Anaesthetic for Caesarean Birth

Information for Patients

The aim of this leaflet is to provide you with information regarding general anaesthesia for caesarean birth. You can also discuss this in more detail with your anaesthetist.

What is a general anaesthetic?

A general anaesthetic means giving you medicines to put you into a deep sleep. This means you are unconscious and do not feel pain during the operation.

Why might I need a general anaesthetic for caesarean birth?

Most caesarean births are performed under regional anaesthesia (i.e. spinal or epidural) but there are some situations where a general anaesthetic is performed:

- You have chosen to have one.
- Your baby needs to be born very quickly, and there isn't time for a spinal or epidural to work.
- You have a condition that stops your blood clotting properly, which can make a spinal or epidural unsafe.
- Something about your back or spine makes a spinal or epidural difficult or impossible to do.
- Occasionally, a spinal or epidural was tried but it couldn't be placed in the correct spot or it didn't work well enough for a caesarean to be performed.

There are also occasions where a general anaesthetic needs to be performed after the baby is born. Examples include a retained placenta or ongoing bleeding after birth. The general anaesthetic itself is given in a similar way in these situations, though your baby will have already been born.

What happens when you have a general anaesthetic?

- You will have a small tube (a cannula) placed into a vein in your arm. This is used to give you fluids and medicines during the operation.
- Monitoring (i.e. blood pressure, oxygen levels, heart rate) will be applied so we can keep a close eye on you throughout the procedure.
- Compression boots will also be put onto your calves to help minimise the chance of blood clots.
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- You will usually be given a medicine to reduce the acid in your stomach. This reduces the chance of acid passing into your lungs when you are asleep.
- A checklist will be performed ensuring you are the correct patient and that the consent is correct.
- You will be given oxygen through a facemask. Oxygen may also be given to you through some nasal prongs.
- A thin tube (a catheter) will be passed into your bladder to keep it empty during surgery. This will be removed once you no longer need it, usually the day after.
- Your tummy will be cleaned and prepped by the obstetrician while you are being put to sleep, so everything is ready for them to start as soon as you are unconscious.
- The anaesthetic doctor will give you medicine into your cannula that slowly sends you to sleep. It can feel cold or a bit sharp in your arm for a few seconds. This is normal.
- You may notice some gentle pressure on the front of your neck as you drift off. This is once again to avoid any acid in your stomach going into your lungs.
- Once asleep, the obstetricians will deliver your baby and placenta. While asleep, the anaesthetist will give you painkillers. You may also be given local anaesthetic injections into your tummy to help with pain relief after the procedure.
- Once the operation is complete, you will be woken up and be taken to recovery.
- Once you are awake, your birth partner and baby can be brought to you.

Will my birth partner be with me if I have a general anaesthetic?

Your birth partner will not be able to be with you during the operation. However, they will be close by and they will be kept updated by the team. While you are asleep, they can be with your baby when they are born. Once you are awake and settled, they will be able to come and join you.

What happens to my baby after it is born if I am asleep?

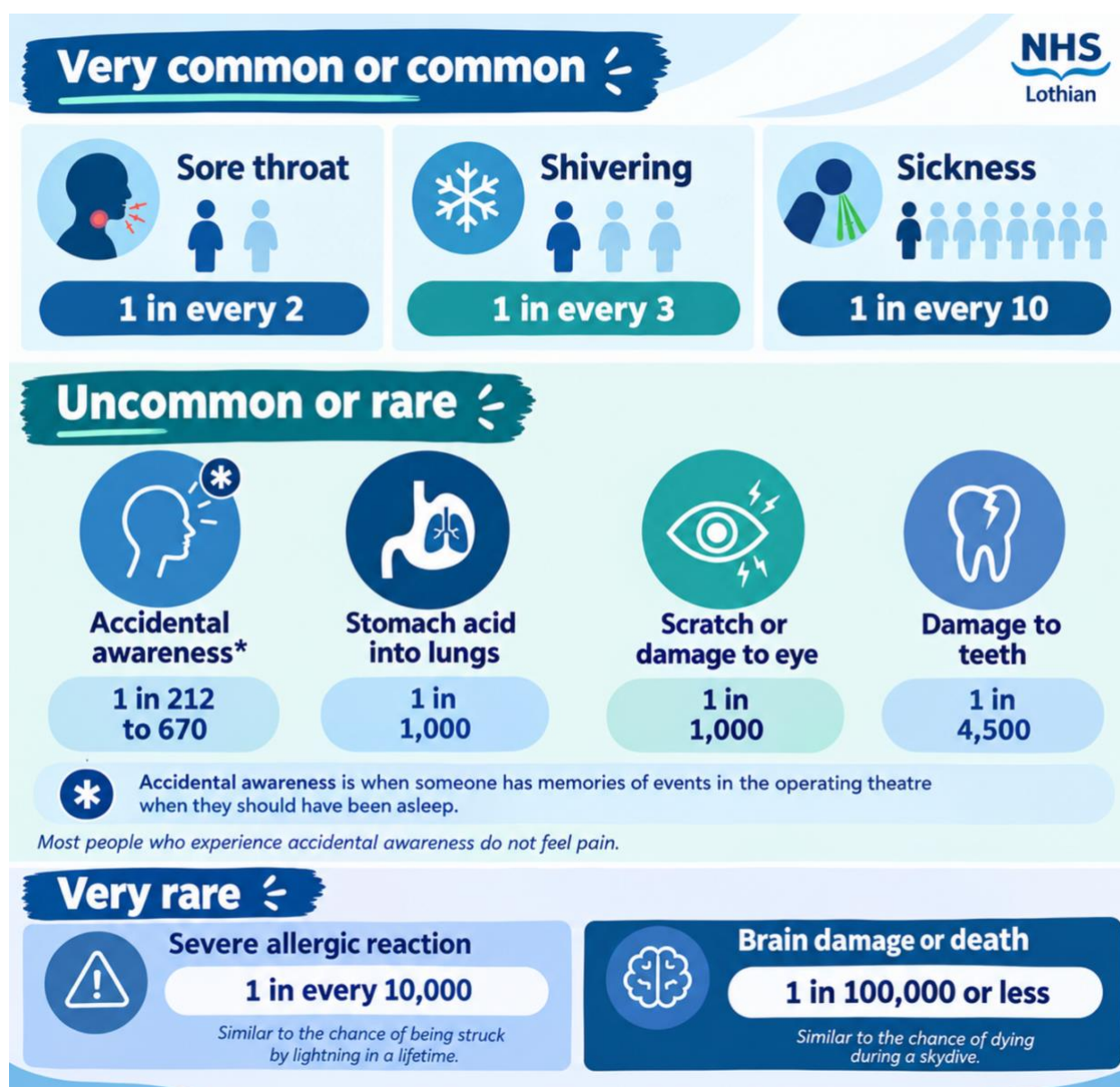
A member of the neonatal team will be there for the birth. As soon as your baby arrives, your midwife will dry them and check them over. If your baby is well, your midwife will look after them until you wake up. Your birth partner can also be with them until you are awake. If your baby needs a little extra help with their breathing which is not uncommon after a caesarean birth, the neonatal team will step in and care for them.

What happens when I wake up?

When you wake up, you may feel sleepy and groggy at first. This is normal and will wear off with time. It is also normal to feel some pain after the operation and you may feel a bit sick. Painkillers and anti-sickness medicine are available whenever you need them, so just let your midwife or nurse know.

Are there any risks of general anaesthetic?

Around 15,000 patients in the UK have a caesarean birth under general anaesthetic each year. For the vast majority, it goes smoothly and without problems. However, as with any anaesthetic, there are some risks and side-effects you should know about, which are set out below.



This leaflet was produced by the obstetric anaesthetists at the Royal Infirmary of Edinburgh. There are more excellent resources which you can read including those published by NHS Lothian and LabourPains.org. Scan the QR codes to access these.



[NHSLothian.scot](https://www.nhs.uk/lothian)



[LabourPains.org](https://labourpains.org)